

Tokyo Drift:

The Sonic Graffiti of the Tokyoite Underground

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TOKYO
DRIFT
The Sonic Graffiti of the Tokyoite Underground

Cover Art: *Tokyo Drift* (2025) by the author
"Fashion, sound, movement. The graffiti of the soul."

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PROLOGUE

My fascination with Japanese hip hop began during sixth form when my tutor gave me the introduction to Ian Condry's "Hip Hop Japan" (2006) as part of my mock interview preparation material. Giving an academic foundation to my admiration of Japanese fashion subcultures, this extract marked the start of my journey into the Tokyoite underground, taking my studies away from my desk and into the real world. I found myself eager to answer — how did a musical culture rooted in African American struggle dig itself into Tokyo's nightlife and subcultural makeup? My academic curiosity blossomed into the desire to see and experience this world firsthand.

Tokyo's underground club scene is a contradiction, living in the future yet bound by the past, simultaneously bold but respectful. The neon sea of Shibuya never slept, and the warm haze shrouding Shimokitazawa held everyone in its grasp; I entered a world where sound, fashion, and movement intersected through subcultural expression, like the careful chaos of a graffitied wall. Tokyo is the convergence of past, present, and future, a constant tug-of-war between creative freedom and corporate efficiency. The underground club scene is a coded language spoken through silhouettes and basslines; rebellion was the only rule, and everywhere I went a new colour rubbed off on me. Like graffitied signatures, each encounter added depth to my understanding of Tokyo's creative subcultures.

This ethnography explores how the body is a canvas, tagging bodies with personal identity within Tokyo's underground. Constructed from theories of embodiment, affect, and subcultural capital, my research examines how Tokyoite creatives convey meaning and emotion through music, fashion, and movement. At the heart of this study is an inquiry into the meaning of subjectivity; I explore how performing the self in a world oversaturated by symbolic language is possible.

I conducted fieldwork in Shibuya and Shimokitazawa in August 2024, where I engaged in structured interviews with DJs and rappers, and immersed myself in the Tokyoite clubbing scene through participant observation. My theoretical inspiration grounds itself in the ethnographic accounts of Condry (2006), Neate (2004), and Wood (1997), detailing their experiences in the Japanese hip hop scene at the turn of the century. Through their voices I was able to build a temporal understanding of the Tokyoite underground scene and inform my position as a researcher 20 years later. While the language barrier and late-night interviews at clubs presented challenges, the doses of information I gathered from each event offered rich insights into the mechanics of Tokyo's subcultural structure.

This ethnography argues that the Tokyoite underground is built on a performative archive of resistance; the body becomes a site for the negotiation of identity, nostalgia, and affective exchange. By looking at the body as a canvas for personal expression and cultural archives, Tokyo's underground club culture nurtures self-expression through an embodied resistance against passive consumption of commercialised music and fashion.

Methodology

2.1 Fieldwork Duration & Sites

My study into Tokyo's underground required qualitative fieldwork because of my desire to understand the affective power of the underground subcultural community through movement, fashion, and music. Following Sarah Pink's model of sensory ethnography, my methodology relies on the body as a research instrument, looking into sound, emotion, and atmosphere as forms of data. Pink's understanding of an ethnography as a "process of creating and representing knowledge or ways of knowing" (Pink, 2015, 35) rings true in my approach to the Tokyoite club scene. I embodied my research and led with instinct, recording the affective changes in my atmosphere through my engagement with the setting and the people. Pink's model of sensory ethnography

feeds into my approach to embodiment in this study. Elevating my approach through the work of Csordas (1990), I approach embodiment as a methodological orientation, understanding that embodiment is constructed through practice, movement, and affective exchange. My immersion in the Tokyoite clubbing scene sought to trace how performance and fashion emphasise the body as a site for cultural meaning. Participant observation from within the club is thus necessary for understanding the true meaning of embodiment.

2.2 Methods & Data Collection

My fieldwork was conducted over three weeks between August and September of 2024, focusing on Tokyo's key creative and nightlife districts. I chose these areas — Shibuya and Shimokitazawa — for their particular density of subcultures and active nightlife. Shibuya is the heart of the Tokyoite nightlife, with clubs and bars around every corner. Shimokitazawa, its quieter neighbour, assumes a more controlled, yet equally buzzing, nightlife, where class meets subcultural rebellion in intimate clubbing settings.

I visited 8 different clubs, engaging in participant observation at each, and conducted 4 formal interviews, each at different cafes around Shibuya. I held two semi-structured interviews, one at a family friend's house, and the other in a live club setting, and 12 informal conversations with DJs, producers, fashion designers, and club owners. These encounters were recorded through fieldnotes, voice recordings, and reflective journalling after each event. I also conducted one email interview. The three weeks of my research trip were divided between research and exploring the city with my family, and the time I had to research was split between clubbing and interviewing. Each interview lasted around an hour, and all the formal interviews were recorded on my camera. Over the course of my 8 club visits, I carefully observed the ways in which participants interact within the club, as well as how the DJ is influenced and influences the audience. Embodiment stood at the core of my research.

2.3 Researcher Positionality & Ethical Considerations

My involvement in the field was challenged by various factors. As a 20-year-old foreign woman in Japan, I understood my limits when conducting my research. Contrary to the circumstances surrounding Condry, Wood, or Neate, my position as a young foreign woman made me more vulnerable in the field. Lines were often blurred between me and the clubgoers, but that did not weaken my research; rather, it gave me a richer understanding of the culture and how gender and race are perceived in the Tokyoite underground.

Conducting ethnographic research requires an understanding of the ethics and safety behind it. Each of my formal interview participants signed a consent form, where they had the opportunity to remain anonymous or mentioned by name in my project. Clubbing presented a few risks to my research. As a young foreign woman, I was aware of the social dynamics and physical vulnerability. I ensured my family knew my location and prioritised public spaces for interviews where possible. In addition to this, my sensory approach to research risked blurring relational boundaries between me and my participants. While I engaged in the clubbing scene, I maintained my distance and navigated informal conversations with care, anonymising personal data and understanding my position as a researcher rather than friend.

2.4 Language & Interpretation

Speech is the most common form of communication; the speaker and listener serve as actors in a complex network of meaning and interpretation. Interpreters do not merely translate what was received but embody the meaning of the speaker. Through the work of Alcoff (1991), we can view interpretation as a form of embodied performance and a challenge to authenticity.

The language barrier was the greatest drawback for my interviews; my limited knowledge of the Japanese language got me to the train station but could not help me through a passionate discussion on the science behind Japanese rap. Linda Alcoff writes about the nuance of meaning afforded by an interpreter, arguing that the original speaker is "no more privileged than any other

person who articulates those views" (Alcoff, 1991, p.28). This creates a tension between speech and meaning, adding a layer of depth to my research. However, Alcoff's argument implies the positioning of the interpreter as a performer in the construction of ethnographic meaning — the interpreter embodied the words that were said, transmitting them to me through his lens. Both the interviewee and interpreter articulated the same view, but the difference lies in how I receive the information. Nick Stone served as my interpreter for my interview with Dabo, and I was aware that interpretation is a form of creating meaning; the interpreter's subjectivity was a key consideration in my analysis. This tension of language coloured my research and gave greater nuance to how I approached the field.

Theoretical Framework

My approach to the Tokyoite underground is inspired by Schacter's theory of graffiti as ornament. My journey through ideas of embodiment, affect, and sound is built on an understanding of Tokyo club culture as a graffitied wall. This visual metaphor serves as the conceptual spine of my ethnography, rationalising how bodies interact with time, space, and memory.

3.1 Ornamentation as Method

My initial approach to this project sought to theorise the body as a canvas, drawn from the work of Pierre Bourdieu. However, upon reading Schacter's chapter on "Graffiti and Street Art as Ornament" (2016, p.141), I developed this idea and began to understand the club as a canvas and the body as a social artefact of inscription. Schacter understands graffiti as an affective ornament (2016, p. 144), serving as visual rebellion that tags physical spaces. In a similar way, the body is a social artefact that bears the marks of the past and present, serving simultaneously as archives and sites for creative innovation. The act of ornamentation is not limited to physical walls but invades spaces and stains the body.

3.2 Affect Theory and Stickiness

Affect Theory ties my research together, understanding clubs as affective spaces rife with emotion. Through Margaret Wetherell's and Theresa Brennan's writings on affect and embodied relationships, clubbing must be understood as an inherently social and affective act. Brennan employs a philosophical approach to affect in her 2004 work The Transmission of Affect, theorising affect as energetic and fluid, moving between people within an environment often without our consent. Wetherell's work (2012) views affect as produced by social practices, rather than being the catalyst for social interaction. Affect is always social, moving knowingly between bodies in everyday life and creating hubs of affective networks. I look at both representations of affect theory, theorising both the affective atmospheres of clubs and the impact of identity and performance on the transmission of affect between bodies.

3.3 Embodiment and Capital

Embodiment is a central theory for this project, serving to underpin my research. My initial reading brought me to Bourdieu's work on the social world (1971). He argued that the body is central to our understanding of the construction of society. My research uses Bourdieu's work as its initial flame, before uncovering the approach to embodiment proposed by Csordas (1990). Instead of understanding embodiment as a product of culture, this project sets out to understand how culture is constructed through the interaction between bodies and the complexity of embodiment across subcultures. Merging Bourdieu's concept of habitus (Maton, 2012, p.65) with Csordas's theory on embodiment, I propose that embodiment is not aesthetic but symbolic.

3.4 Subcultural Economics

As theorised by Sarah Thornton (1995), subcultural capital illustrates how fashion, music, and movement converge to create branches of expression unique but seamlessly integrated into the larger society. Drawing upon the power of the media and the pace of youth culture, I use

Thornton's approach to subcultural capital to reason with the complexities of the Tokyoite underground scene, looking at how information and aesthetics circulate throughout a subculture. Subcultures thrive on "the construction of a style, in a gesture of defiance or contempt. It signals a Refusal" (Hedbige, 1979, p.3). My ethnography hinges on an understanding of subcultures as specific nodes of expression and experimentation, entering the Tokyoite underground with a wide lens.

The aesthetic capital of the Tokyoite underground subculture greatly contrasts the industry capital that dominates the New York City creative scene. I take Currid-Halkett's "economics of the dance floor" (2009, p.87) as a key comparison point against my experience in the Tokyo clubbing scene, adding nuance to my analysis and contextualising the growth of the Tokyoite underground within our constantly globalising creative world.

These lenses give my ethnography a strong focus on the body as a social artefact, helping to rationalise the constant negotiation with identity that defines the Tokyoite underground.

CHAPTER 1: THE GENESIS OF JAPANESE RAP

Graffiti is to walls what fashion is to the body and what music is to the soul: an artistic act of rebellion. Spray paint, clothing, and sound are all fleeting forms of inscription, temporary markings made to express but not last. Taking Schacter's theorisation of graffiti as ornament (2016), this ethnography grounds itself through graffiti as a conceptual framework. I have come to understand the Tokyoite underground as a graffitied wall, rewritten nightly through style, bodies, and music.

Japanese hip hop, while rooted in African American cultural aesthetics, has developed into a distinctly local expression of identity (Condry, 2004; Manabe, 2013). While American influence impacts the choices of Japanese hip hoppers, the country's unique approach to clubbing, music, and externalised expression planted the seeds for an entirely new culture, one that resembles its American mother but assumes a persona of its own.

In her analysis of the colourful club culture of New York City, Currid-Halkett (2009) emphasises the strength and importance of the artist network. In such a geographically large city, packed with cloud-touching skyscrapers and noisy streets, artists find a way to remain connected through social interaction. The art world is social, and clubbing is a valuable way to initiate a "collision of culture" necessary for making new creative connections; "nightclubs are laboratories for new fashion and new sounds and a way for creative people to get together" (Currid-Halkett, 2009, p.88). Currid-Halkett's analogy paints an image of nightclubs as experimental yet controlled, innovative yet tactical. My conceptual framework builds on this, understanding clubs as walls in motion, constantly being graffitied on. Graffitied walls are laboratories too; the canvas they provide evolves with time, holding histories of experimentation, expression, and freedom.

The difference between the New Yorker and Tokyoite clubbing scenes is the negotiation between the art and the origin. Hip hop originated in New York; the tags that are inscribed in the grammar of hip hop are rooted in the local culture. However, Japan borrowed American paint and used it on Japanese walls, forcing artists to reason with the clash between personal and social identity. Dabo was one of the first artists to bring American hip hop's code into Japanese culture. Being the face of Def Jam Japan gave him the tools to carry American tags—clothes, ideologies, and sound—into Japan, and people began to echo him. The globalisation of hip hop can be theorised through the conceptual understanding of graffiti; while art styles can be carried across the globe, each signature is unique and each wall holds a different affective history. If graffiti serves as both a personal and cultural ornament, as Schacter argues, then we can build a narrative that looks at hip hop not only as the diffusion of an aesthetic, but the transmission of affect.

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I had been in Japan for just under a week; we were slowly getting over our jet lag and beginning to settle into a new routine. Nick Stone, a producer and manager for some of the best DJs in Japan, invited me and my family for a dinner at his place to welcome us to Tokyo.

"So, who are you thinking of meeting with?" Nick asked as I was making a small tuna roll at the dinner table. "I reached out to some DJs like Yanny, YESBØWY," I replied, "And I've also contacted some rappers. Do you know Dabo? He's one of my favourites."

I was interrupted by Nyoro, his wife, who interjected from the kitchen, "Dabo? We know him! He lives just down the street; we're good friends with him." Nick pulled out his phone and agreed with Nyoro before I had time to process what she had just said,

"Yeah, he lives just here, he can come and join us for dinner if you'd like." Still in disbelief by what the pair was telling me, I looked over to my mum, who was beaming at me with a quiet sense of surprise. *Say yes*, her eyes told me.

My interview with Dabo was one of the most exciting conversations I have ever had about hip hop. Not only did Dabo's presence leave a great impression on me, but the atmosphere too; Sade's soft vocals hummed in the background, the kids were playing Mario Kart in the neighbouring room, and Dabo sat opposite me on the dining table in a tank top and basketball shorts snacking on edamame beans. There was an unexpected intimacy while I was interviewing a hip hop legend across a dinner table. We built momentum as I started to bounce off his answers; Nick was equally, if not more, intrigued by Dabo's answers as I was, relaying his words to me with unmatched enthusiasm. Through his translation, Nick co-inscribed Dabo's words into the space, affectively tagging them. As Alcoff (1991) argues, words are never translated cleanly, rather they are always filtered through positionality. Nick translated Dabo's words, but he also translated his *affect*: his tone, reverence, and relationship to the culture. Nick's embodied fluency in hip hop culture graffitied Dabo's words, reaching me as a collaboration, co-inscribed through shared memory.

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Dabo's career spans across key moments in hip hop's development in Japan, beginning in the 90s during a time when Japanese hip hop was coloured by the debate of authenticity. By adopting African American aesthetics, Japanese youth used their bodies as canvases to express their identity with borrowed codes. This is an embodied inscription that negotiates the material and symbolic within a global culture. Hip hop is a musical culture built upon inheritance and nostalgia; symbolic capital (Bourdieu, 1971) is born out of the context of the clothes worn and the beats used. Understanding this context transforms the body from a passive placeholder to an active participant in the hip hop subculture. Following Ahmed's theorisation of embodiment, I understand the hip hop body as both an archive and a site for innovation, styled and performed in uniquely expressive ways. I draw upon Schacter's conceptualisation of graffiti as ornament to elevate this idea to look beyond the physical body and into the ways in which Japanese artists rewrite their own underground narrative.

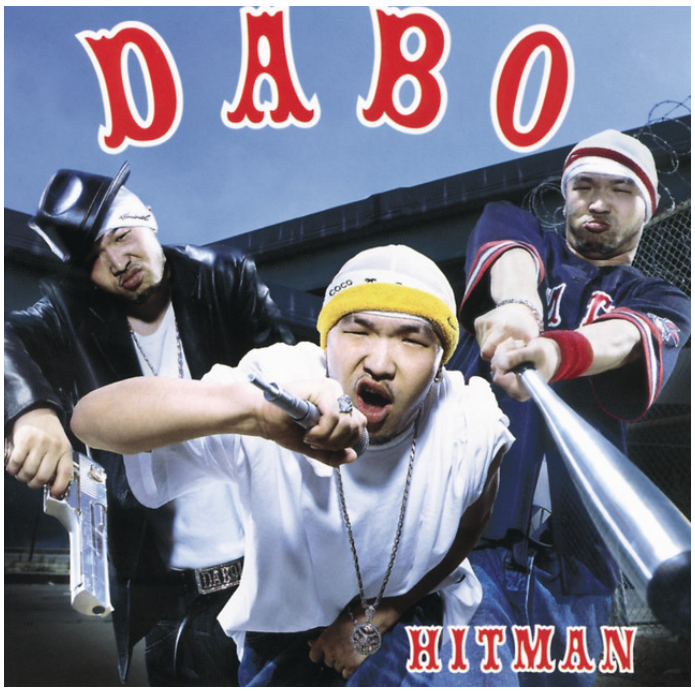


Figure 1. *Hitman*, Dabo, 2002. (Def Jam Japan)

Dabo represents the early integration of hip hop into Japanese society – an artist making music under the rule of the American record label, Def Jam Japan, and thrown into a conflict between his local culture and that of American rap. Dabo only began with Def Jam Japan in 2002, thus the years leading up to his mainstream breakthrough were spent building skills and "making skilful lyrics by adjusting wordplay" (Nick, p.c, 2024)[1]. The cultural body of hip hoppers in Japan is built upon a complex foundation that creates a completely different persona than their American counterparts. Building from Dabo's history in masterful Japanese rap, his 2002 debut album, *Hitman* (Figure 1), epitomises the collision between cultural and commercial in hip hop, forcing Dabo to reconcile with the local and global within his own artistic persona. Condry commented on the use of stereotypical American iconography on this album cover, arguing that the presentation of African American culture here "reinforces stereotypes" that likely enforces the idea that "Japanese hip hop is merely imitation" (Condry, 2006, p.27). However, during my interview with Dabo I was given a new perspective into the choice of clothes in the album cover.

[1] "p.c." denotes *personal communication*. These include all conversations with participants during fieldwork.

"That was Def Jam Japan," Dabo told me. "They gave me the clothes for this shoot." *Hitman*'s album cover is an act of visual tagging. This harks back to Gell's notion of *artefactual agency*, looking at the link between ornamented objects and their human counterparts. Dabo's body becomes a social artefact on which he transmitted his creative agency into the Japanese hip hop scene. In Bourdieu's sense, the clothes Dabo wore serve as symbolic capital that hold status and authenticity within the hip hop subculture. However, understanding Gell allows us to view his clothes as a performance that mediates social agency through the negotiation between culture and personal expression. This is not a reproduction of American aesthetics but an affective ornamentation (Schacter, 2016). Dabo's acknowledgement that these clothes were chosen by Def Jam Japan only highlight this idea; this cover picture is a conscious construction of identity, with the aim of adapting hip hop's message to his Japanese audience.

This album was released under Def Jam Japan, and Dabo was "charged as the dude who brings the American lifestyle to Japan via the Def Jam brand" (Nick, p.c, 2024). Dabo's album showed Japanese youth that "you could live that lifestyle here in Japan", it was less about appropriating African American culture but about "doing it together" (2024):

> "From the 90s it was about lyricism and going to clubs and showing your skills. Come the 2000s, it was all about getting money [...]. In Japan, which was starting to become established, people could get those cars and those clothes – they could do whatever people were doing in those videos. It wasn't somewhere way out there, which is what it used to be in the 90s." (Nick, p.c, 2024)

Nick's reflection on the early Japanese hip hop scene mirrors Condry's characterisation of the third era of Japanese hip hop, circa 2000-present, which values "widening diversity without a centre" (Condry, 2004, p.53). Dabo's embodiment of hip hop through clothes and mannerisms as well as music speaks to the depth of artistic personae and the importance of the body as the home of cultural expression.

The idea that the American hip hop lifestyle was achievable is what drew Japanese artists towards the genre. Injecting a historically and culturally significant genre with the experiences of Japanese youth created new narratives; artists like Dabo were not merely part of the global hip hop narrative, they were reshaping it.

To graffiti the Tokyo body is to scream into the void through fashion, sound, and sweat. It is about rewriting the manifesto of efficiency and uniformity and stage rebellion on the skin. The Tokyoite underground is a collision of culture; every outfit is a tag and every beat is an attempt to break through the silence and reach freedom within controlled chaos. As well as Dabo, Coma-Chi, one of Japan's earliest female rappers, paints local skin with global colours, performing on soil tainted by mimicry. This chapter understands their bodies as walls in motion, stained with life and fuelled by resistance.

Coma-Chi does not decorate the scene, she disrupts it. Like a rose in a field of tulips, her thorns are proof that women can bleed hip hop, not just exist within the subculture. Both Dabo and Coma-Chi released self-naming tracks in their debut albums – "D.A.B.O" (2002) and "Name Tag" (2009). Coma-chi collaborated with NYC producer Black Spade for "Name Tag", rooting her sound in the birthplace of hip hop as inheritance rather than mimicry. While this song is built above an American beat, the lyrics are achingly personal, proclaiming her mission and marking her ground in the Japanese hip hop scene:

まあまたそれも人気の証	Guess that's just proof of my fame
棒立ちのかかしじゃなく	I'm no frozen scarecrow
待ったナシの能動的な方法	I act—no hesitation, kinetic method
ここがリアル 刻み込む	This is what's real — carving in my name
ずっとこの場所にいる	Always right here

– Coma-Chi, "Name Tag" (2009)

These lyrics, from the first verse of "Name Tag", are a glimpse into the fierce desire for personal identity in Coma-Chi's hip hop persona, graffitiing across Japanese walls with a paint she

created. My interview with Coma-Chi unveiled how this song served as the first step towards the formation of her hip hop persona. "This song was my first vinyl so I wanted to express myself and my story." (Coma-Chi, p.c., 2024). While the societal narrative pushed for women to be more "lady-like or girlish", forcing women to be someone they're not, Coma-Chi redirected this energy, inscribing a new code onto the Japanese wall. Her most recent album, *Oto* (2024), is a celebration of Japanese culture through hip hop, integrating Japanese instruments and iconography into the globalised genre.

The main difference between Dabo and Coma-Chi lies in their artistic inscription. While my conceptualisation of graffiti serves as a levelling metaphor for all artistic expression, the surface that artists paint on is never neutral, especially for women in hip hop. Dabo's body is a concrete wall, graffitied with the trials of his career, layered with the symbolic capital of Def Jam Japan, and tagged by the impact of hip hop's globalisation. Coma-Chi, however, began her career painting on a stained glass window; her body was fragile and dangerously exposed. Trying to assemble herself within the cracks of a musical culture so rooted in masculinity, Coma-Chi had to rewrite the grammar of hip hop not only as a Japanese rapper but as a woman too. Even though her early success came from a record label, this does not come across as privilege but rather a strategic approach to exposure and rebirth that gave women the visibility they rarely received in this culture. Both the concrete wall and stained glass window bear the signs of time, which we recognise as paint.

Ahmed theorises that objects become "sticky" through repeated contact (2004, p.11), saturated with the affective traces of those who interact with it. In this sense, affective surfaces become relational archives; graffitied walls bear the tags of artists, and stained glass windows transmit coloured light, temporarily altering our reality. A wall without tags is forgettable, a glass window without stains is invisible, and a body without contact and expression resists creativity. The self-naming tracks that both artists released serve as sonic tags onto the Japanese hip hop

scene, marking their Japanese names using American paint. The cultural authorship that is developed through collaboration between cultures – Dabo borrowed clothes and Coma-Chi borrowed beats – reflects the body as a social artefact. Our bodies become tagged by what we consume and create. In this way, we can carefully link bodies to curated materials; the body wears clothes, speaks in a certain accent, wears a specific scent *for* those around them. Notice I said *for*. Although we dress for ourselves first, we are conscious of how the world interacts with us; identity is always formed through relationality, and so our visual tagging is important. Dabo and Coma-Chi both established their presence in the Japanese hip hop scene through the power of visibility, their bodies are formed through international contact, inscribed by foreign paint, and translate this idea onto the Japanese hip hop scene.

CHAPTER 2: BODY AS NOSTALGIC CANVAS

Graffitied walls carry history, layers of paint representing an evolution of style and personality. By aligning with Schacter's theorisation of graffiti as ornament, the wall becomes an aesthetic site of inscription, which translates into our understanding of embodiment in hip hop and the power of the body as a social artefact. In hip hop, fashion is a parergon – what Derrida calls the "beside-the-work" (Schacter), standing adjacent to sound and movement and building tension between the personal and the social. Clothes cover the body, shield from nakedness, both physically and symbolically; fashion is at once social and intimate.

Nostalgia is a big motivating factor for hip hop artists and has influenced the choices made by artists and fans until today. Style exposes history, rewriting the body in a new context that is haunted by its past but forced to reconcile with the present. In Tokyo's underground clubs, nostalgia is not merely a longing for the past, but a strategic aesthetic that affirms subcultural belonging. Drawing from Ahmed's understanding of emotions as a compass, nostalgia clings to people, making them "saturated with affect" (Ahmed, 2004, p.11). Ahmed says that emotions stick through contact; in this case, style is the site of contact. This affective pull holds the hip hop subculture together, standing on the fine line between the materialistic and ideological that is built on a fragile foundation of laws and rebellion. Wetherell's view that affect is produced by social practices (2014) feeds into our understanding of the importance of nostalgia as a "sticky" emotion within the hip hop subculture, elevating our study from analysing the graffiti we see on the wall to uncovering what is hidden under the layers of paint.

This chapter argues that the body serves as an ornamental archive inscribed by subcultural identity and affective memory. In the Tokyoite underground, artists balance aesthetics with

nostalgia, creating unique identities that draw on different aspects of the past and present. Taking Thornton's subcultural capital as our starting point, this chapter explores how the Tokyoite body is both a site for memory and cultural reinvention.

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It was 4:50 p.m. on a warm Saturday, I hurried through the streets of Shibuya, arriving at an unmarked metal door – the hidden entrance to WOMB. Two men were standing outside, equally confused by the blank door with no handle in sight. The faint reminiscence of a beat and roaring crowds told me I was at the right place, but with no mobile data and no one to contact, I was stuck outside. Minutes of waiting paid off as someone opened the door from inside and I was engulfed by the familiar smell of old smoke that hung low in all Tokyoite clubs. There was noise coming from every direction; people talking, admiring the turntables on display, or dancing on the small dance floor off the main corridor. The main attraction was up a spiral set of stairs, sound dripping from above as a loud MC and his equally excited crowd were spurring on the finalists.

Witnessing this DMC competition was one of the most invigorating experiences during my trip; people watched in awe as the DJs created complex beats out of two vinyl disks and a mixer. As Brennan suggests, affect is transmitted between bodies, building tension and holding the space together. The embodied emotion present on stage draws upon Ahmed's understanding of the "stickiness" of emotion; the DJs hold their audience in an affective whirlpool, imprinting their passion onto us.

Each set had an embodied performative element to it. Most of the DJs were wearing oversized t-shirts and baggy jeans, arms bare so as to not obstruct themselves from spinning. The choice of clothing interestingly reflected a subcultural hallmark that has anchored Japanese hip hop since its early years. In the 1970s hip hop fashion was heavily influenced by youth culture in the Bronx; Caroline Shackelford explains that the "ill-fitting nature of inner-city hand-me-downs" popularised this style of clothing (2022), grounding this aesthetic in a deeper cultural history. Thus,

hip hop's aesthetics are not random, they are an embodied tribute, an insider's code that holds the subculture together. Fashion operates as subcultural capital (Thornton, 1997), actively shaping and evolving subcultures through trends and influence. In hip hop, nostalgia carries a huge weight; this musical culture encapsulates dance, art, singing, and sound to create a multi-dimensional art form celebrated as a total embodiment of self-expression. If fashion is graffiti, then the body is a social artefact (Schacter), baring the marks of time, history, and human experience that clothes alone cannot show. Only when the paint is sprayed across the wall does it have the affective power as ornament; fashion is inscription, tags on our bodies that elevate our sonic power.

As a country removed from this specific New Yorker tradition, the use of baggy clothes assumed a new meaning, articulated by Shing02 during our interview as being the ability "to do more with less" (Shing02, p.c., 2024), creating outfits that reflect the humble origins of hip hop whilst rooting it in the unique local culture. This 1990s hip hop sentiment stretched into the DJing scene of the 21st century, with DJs such as YESBØWY embodying their music through stylistic tags.

Shing02's ethos of resourcefulness is motivated by the freedom of movement and practicality, bleeding through his musical career into his brand. "Design for me is not so much emotion, it is about function and utility," Shing02 said, "it's really the feedback that I look forward to and that's very similar to music." (Shing02, p.c., 2024). Feedback is a key aspect of all art; it dictates how you move forward and who your key audience would be through affective exchange (Brennan, 2004). The anticipation of feedback that Shing02 describes illustrates the importance of social affect in the MCing and DJing worlds. This builds upon Wetherell's theorisation of affect as produced through social interaction; the power is placed externally rather than originating from within. The motivation behind embodiment in Shing02's craft greatly differs from that of YESBØWY. While the former turns outwards to look in, the latter starts within himself to attract the audience he desires, picking stylistic tags that reflect his artistic persona. YESBØWY emphasises the importance of his forearms being bare, accessorising his hands with jewellery he

designs and "dark green nails", a creative addition to his DJing outfits inspired by a DJ he once saw who wore white gloves. His choices reflect the affective tagging that happens throughout the underground scene; by admiring and reshaping a fashion choice he saw, YESBØWY perfectly illustrates my theorisation of the body as a social artefact, tagged by a new signature and reconfigured by social interaction.

The DMC competition appeared to have an unspoken dress code: oversized t-shirts and baggy jeans, complemented by bucket hats and Afro-American hairstyles — a sartorial homage to 1990s hip hop culture. Hip hop culture digs its roots in fashion as well as music; the replication of hip hop through fashion is an issue that has haunted the Japanese subculture since its birth. Viewing African American culture as an aesthetic to divert themselves away from the mainstream, Japanese hip hoppers subconsciously fell into a cycle of cultural appropriation, as explored by Wood during his journey underground. The idea of appearing "cool" coloured a lot of fashion choices in late 20th century Japanese hip hop. Contrary to the air of collaboration promoted by Nick in the previous chapter, Wood pointed out Japan's obsession with completely consuming African American hip hop culture in the late 1990s (1997, p.63), and I was under the impression that this was a trend that eventually died away. However, seeing this crowd convinced me otherwise. American hip hop culture still reigned as the motherboard for cultures across the world, and so it is no surprise that hip hoppers around Tokyo adopt styles and trends that reflect the West Coast hip hop giants. Wood's experience in Tokyo highlighted the potentially appropriative approach to hip hop taken by some Japanese fans, one whose legacy has bled into the subcultural identity of Japanese hip hoppers until today.

The connection between the audience and the DJ on stage is reflected not only through their attire but through movement and motivation. Clubbing spaces remove the hierarchies of modern-day society, serving as artistic networks where artists, fans, and observers collide. In this competition specifically, however, there must be a hierarchy. The DJs painted their audiences,

tagging them with their music and movement, in the hopes of winning. Building on from Bourdieu's Habitus, the body serves as a tagged archive that holds history as well as passion, the past and the future simultaneously. Schacter viewed graffitied walls as affective architecture, in a similar way we can see the DJs as highly complex architectures, bleeding on stage and shedding parts of them to give to the crowd. The winner is the one who sheds the most skin, reveals the most stripped wall at the end of their set. DJing is as much about personal expression as it is about the social impact.

INTERLUDE: CLUBBING IS FREEDOM

I've been in Tokyo for two weeks now and my family and I have formed a routine. I started to understand the city's rhythm, how fast to walk on the streets, how to avoid photobombing tourist photographs, and how to blend into the Tokyoite nightlife. Tokyo screams so loud at night; the uniform mundanity of daylight is violently flipped on its head as soon as the sun sets and the last train makes its final stop. During one of my interviews I was invited to HVEN, a club in Kamimeguro, to meet Robin Rastenberger, the founder of Tokyo Love Hotels and owner of HVEN. I waded through Tokyo at dusk, the moment when salarymen and clubgoers collide in train carriages and slide like oil over water in the streets. The disruption between day and night mirrored the distance between the sun and the moon, ever-present in the same world but never close enough to touch each other.

It was 9pm and I was walking through the rain, Google maps in hand, cargo skirt flowing in the warm evening air. I arrived in front of a tall, barbed wire fence. Google maps was seemingly asking me to climb over it, claiming that the club was a straight line through the fence. Confused and stuck in the rain, I walked around the area under a railway bridge in the hopes of finding an entrance. I passed a small alleyway lit by an endless row of lamp posts; out of all the options for a club entrance, that seemed the most plausible, yet most mysterious. I heard faint whispers carried by the wind as I hesitantly walked down this alley. The sight of a man behind a counter and a pile of umbrellas gave me a sense of relief; I finally found it.

"That's what makes it more fun," Robin told me during our interview, after I told him how long it took me to find the entrance, "Where is the excitement in knowing how to get into the club?" Each room in HVEN had a specific atmosphere that encased it, and with that a different

crowd. The main room, characteristically named The Void, was the dance floor – a dark walled room with a projector pointing at one wall and a small, raised platform in the middle of the room. This space was juxtaposed by the adjacent room, the Hanger, a dining room-esque room with a large metal table anchoring the space and art lining the walls. Pop ups and exhibitions rotated with each event, an initiative started by Robin and Tokyo Love Hotels to promote independent artists. The lighting was much softer, people's voices created a blanket of noise just loud enough to hear your own thoughts. Robin had a vision to revolutionise the party culture of Tokyo and did so in 2017 through Tokyo Love Hotels. Despite a rocky start due to a resistance from mainstream Japanese culture, Robin spearheaded a revolution in clubbing: "there was nothing that existed like this before, and Love Hotels has somehow over the past 7 years managed to change what a clubbing event entails" (2024). It was only after he said this that I realised that most of the clubs and DJ bars I went to during my trip featured an exhibit or pop-up, "it's almost like a must" (Robin, p.c., 2024) in the Tokyoite clubbing scene now. The Hanger was lined with floor to ceiling windows, separating this indoor space from The Deck, the smoking area that hugged the exterior of the club. The level of intimacy across these three rooms decreased as I moved through the club, but the connection between bodies remained.

"It's a bit scary for someone, especially if you're talking about a typical Japanese person, to follow where there's no leader, no one to guide you" (Rastenberger, p.c, 2024). Robin explained how the architecture of the club reflects his dedication to making HVEN a comfortable atmosphere for his customers. Starting from the mysterious entrance and running through to the large windows, HVEN is an architectural masterclass in connection. Socialising is all about people, the interactions between bodies, both verbal and silent. Robin unveiled how HVEN is built "so that you have direct access to view people's faces without being so obvious" (2024). Windows that connect each room together – shown in the layout (Figure 2) – to add separation between people. "It's like you're wearing sunglasses", Robin remarked, as we peered into the Hanger through the glass wall. After our interview I observed how the night unfolded, floating between the rooms and

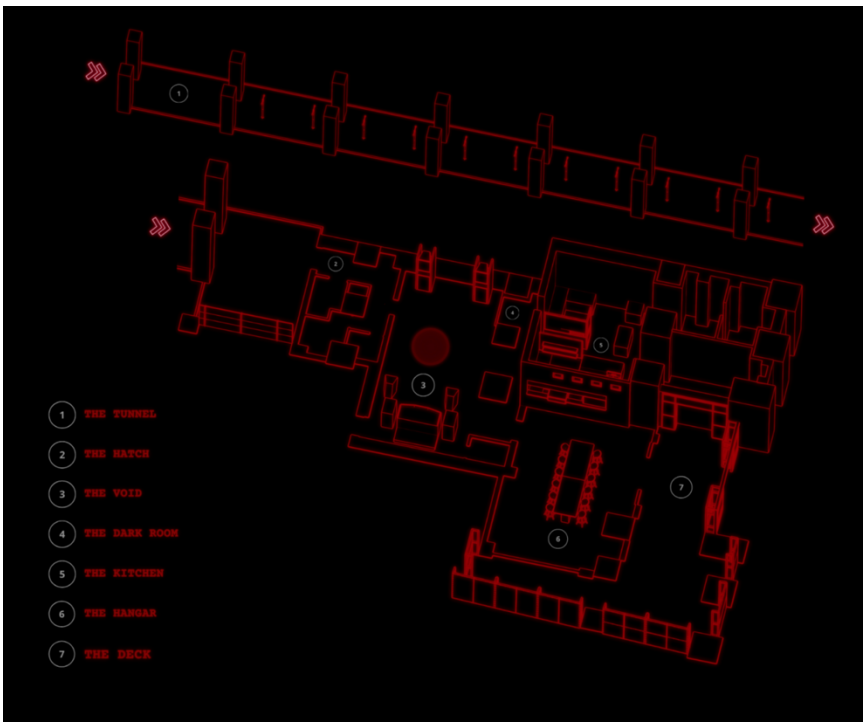


Figure 2: Layout of HVEN. Source: HVEN website (accessed 25 April 2025)

engaging with some of the club goers. It was refreshing to see a space where socialising was at the fore, different groups of people shared the same space, and all contributed a part of themselves. This was specifically evident as it approached 01:00am. Spotlights danced around the dance floor as the DJ interacted with her audience, making beat after beat that kept the audience hyped. At that moment I understood what Robin was trying to achieve through HVEN: the search for a collective euphoria, spurred on by the intermingling of individual passion.

The stark contrast between Tokyo and cities in Europe is the latter's extreme focus on dancing. Robin compared the European style of clubbing involving "1000 people on a dance floor for 8 hours straight" to the "social event" that clubbing has become in Tokyo; "there are raves in the forest for dancing", he told me. Tokyo Love Hotels focuses on inclusivity, a difficult task in a society where everything is niche and "if you're not part of a niche you don't feel like you belong" (Rastenberger, p.c, 2024). Robin went on to explain how subcultures formed in Japan, attributing their prevalence in Japanese society to the "one-minded Japanese mentality". This idea translated itself into subcultures, which are essentially "mini versions of the one-mind; if someone actually

tries to start something people will follow, and they only function within that society" (2024). Japanese subcultures are reliant on a certain societal duty to unify; Japan's "one-mind" mentality has impacted the way in which society functions, putting the collective before the individual in every aspect of life. This results in subcultures being of high importance as structural beams in Japan: "you don't really have the urge to veer out, it's not part of Japanese mentality within society itself. It's one journey, so to speak" (Rastenberger, p.c, 2024). Robin's acknowledgement of the rigidity of subcultures added a layer of depth to my understanding of Japanese culture that I incorrectly assumed. As an outsider, I was unaware of the true meaning and history of subcultures in Japan; my knowledge came from secondary sources (Condry, 2006; Wood, 1997; Neate, 2009; Manabe, 2013). However, my discussion with Robin introduced the idea that subcultures act both as havens of inclusivity but also prisons of ideology.

The aim of Tokyo Love Hotels is to create a space everyone could experience; their first customers were "the inbounds living in Japan" (Rastenberger, p.c, 2024). The fear of the unknown stopped Japanese youth from venturing far beyond the walls of their subcultural norms; they wear the same clothes, eat at the same restaurants, and listen to the same music. Robin cultivated a space for people who don't have their own culture or roots in Japan; he allowed them to bring their culture to create something new. In a sense this style of clubbing resembles Currid-Halkett's (2009) exploration into New York's clubbing scene more so than the Tokyoite scene, looking at clubbing as a means for innovation rather than nostalgia. The affective power that Robin holds as the conductor of this style of clubbing separates him from other creatives in the music industry; he helped to redefine what socialising and clubbing means to Japanese youth, especially post-pandemic. Robin built a wall free from nostalgia. As opposed to the rest of the Tokyoite clubbing scene which valued nostalgia over innovation, Robin innovated a style of clubbing closer to a Currid-Halkettian approach. Forever possessing the scent of wet paint, HVEN's wall simultaneously creates and archives, launching the present into the future in the effort to move

away from the emotional stickiness of nostalgia that formed the foundation of Japan's subcultural society.

So far in this ethnography we have looked at how bodies define the space in which they express themselves. However, through my conversation with Robin, I gained a new perspective, understanding how the club serves as an actor influencing the clubbing experience. Moving away from the notion of subcultural capital, HVEN provides a clean contrast from Tokyo's nostalgic clubbing scene and paves the way for a new era of clubbing, one that takes from the Western fast-paced environment, explored by Currid-Halkett, and skilfully weaves artistic expression with personal identity.

CHAPTER 3: CLUBBING AS PERFORMANCE AND EMBODIMENT

Google Maps told me my interview venue was a 15-minute walk. I can make that, I thought. I told Nyoro I would be back, and I left the DMC competition at top speed, rushing through the dusk Shibuya streets to YESBØWY's bar and gallery for our interview.

The space was a sharp contrast to the busy streets, with a high ceiling and a minimalist feel. The clothes on the racks each reflected a contained sense of creativity, like the eye of a storm. YESBØWY was sitting on a sofa, working on his set for his next gig, a beach club in Okinawa. His outfit was a perfect reflection of his creative persona, oozing with a calm confidence that screamed "I know exactly who I am, and I love it". I was offered a drink, and I chose an iced oolong tea. He served it to me while he drank a red bull and changed up the music from hip hop to a cool afro-beat mix.

There is a certain flair that creatives such as YESBØWY exude; both in his speech and his attire, there was a sense that he has been in fashion since the day he was born. The way he spoke about music, I could tell it was his passion more than anything else. What was interesting about my interview with Yes was the focus on emotion and feeling he placed on his work. The many avenues that his creativity has opened for him have all been motivated by emotion. There was a period, he explained, when he was dating someone who took all his effort. During this period nothing could be done, all his love and emotion were being used on her. This period of instability, followed by a burst of creativity years later, speaks to his unconventional style of work, one that values passion over the industry's fast paced and demanding ideal. When asked about his career,

he became more enthusiastic, opening himself up and talking about art like it was his true love. There is a shortage of creatives who work for their passion. There is no money in DJing and music, or at most very little.

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Our discussion on embodiment thus far has taken theories from Bourdieu, Schacter, and Gell to construct a metaphorical framework focusing on the conceptualisation of graffiti. Viewing the body as a dynamic cultural surface illuminates the impact of performance as an affective accumulation of emotion, gestures and sound. According to Wetherell, affect moves collectively within a shared space, weaving between bodies (2012, p.18); in Tokyo's underground clubbing scene, DJs seize control of this affective flow, manipulating sound and style to draw out emotional responses. Thus, the body is seen as a vessel for cultural transmission as well as a site for performative inscription.

This chapter argues that the club is a site where bodies collide and assume a collective meaning; rather than being seen as individual social artefacts, they become artists on a larger canvas – the club itself. The dynamic relationship between the DJ and the audience creates a current of energy, where affect is transmitted across all bodies present at the club. My interview with YESBØWY revealed the kinetic energy that electrifies the Tokyoite nightlife, exploring how his creative persona injects itself into the affective flow of the club as both a performer and observer. Additionally, I will be mapping YESBØWY onto the larger clubbing scene, understanding how historical restrictions on dancing have influenced bodily expression and fuelling the rebellious nature of underground culture.

"In Tokyo clubs, I think only 20 or 30 people listen to the DJ" (YESBØWY, p.c, 2024). As a DJ, the balance between performing for the audience and for the self is constantly challenged; within the club setting we can understand them as emotional mediators, conducting the affective flow that passes through the atmosphere. YESBØWY comments on the intimacy of his performance,

remarking that "I need just one person listening to my set". This intimacy of the front row emphasises the deeply personal nature of Tokyo's clubbing scene and its focus on affective impact over commercial spectacle.

During our interview YESBØWY talked about his relationship with his audience during sets. He looks at the audience's eyes, checking if they are listening to his music. "A lot of the time", he told me, "The most important people at my sets are the people in the front row, the 5 or 6 people who pay the most attention to my music. Even if there is only one person dancing, I would be happy", he told me. "My music has to reach someone, and I don't mind how many or how few" (YESBØWY, p.c., 2024). Understanding that affect is a fluid concept, passing through interactions between bodies, YESBØWY's passion for DJing and his attentiveness to his audience blurs the boundaries between the artist and observer, reflecting his dual role within the clubbing space. Similarly to how the body serves as a canvas for self-expression through fashion, YESBØWY's sensitivity to his craft ensures that his sets are not just sonic experiences but an exchange of energy.

Creative currency is the paint used to decorate club walls, tagging the space with emotion that sticks to clubgoers. If the body is a social artefact, the club is a museum, lined with affective power and constantly filled with movement, sound, and emotion. The network created within clubs renders societal hierarchies suspended, instead looking at every participant as part of the collective entity of the club. Condry understands this spatial embodiment as the "genba", the place where "something actually happens" (Condry, 2004, p.89). The affective network created within clubs, and the flattening of social hierarchies allows for the genba to be a place of complete creative freedom. The transmission of affect is subconscious and ever-present, and each body brings their graffitied history with them into the space, not only transmitting their present versions but their generational histories too. Following Schacter's argument that graffiti is an ornament in two senses, embodying not only what it means but how it takes over the space, the body enters the club as

history and innovation simultaneously, dripping with creative currency. Emotion circulates between as well as sticks to the body, as explored by Ahmed, and when these emotionally charged bodies collide at the club it stimulates emotional release through embodied performance.

Subcultural capital is strengthened by the dissemination of symbolic acts, and through clubbing, both the DJ and the audience use their bodies to uniquely express themselves; from the clothes they wear to their movements, everyone influences and is influenced by those around them. While Currid-Halkett comments on the importance of New York clubs for the "collision of culture" (2009, p88), where creatives exchange ideas, Thornton's subcultural capital theory (1995) takes this a step further, allowing us to view Tokyoite clubbing not only as an exchange of creativity, but the cultivation of personal expression. The strength of the Tokyoite underground comes from the power of bodily expression as subcultural capital. The freedom of expression, severed from the strict working scene that dominates Japanese culture, is enough to serve as the affective glue holding subcultures together, "earning" subcultural capital in a club is less about status and more about presence, emotionally unguarded and creatively free. The DJ and their audience strike a balance between releasing emotion and strengthening the sense of community within the club, using their bodies as both introspective reflections of and resistance to the rigid social norms of everyday life.

"I feel a lot of Japanese people cannot dance. Not really dance but feeling the music; they cannot do that. So that's why they just drink alcohol and talk to friends" (YESBØWY, p.c., 2024). YESBØWY's comment here reflects the long struggle for dancing freedom that has plagued the Japanese entertainment industry since the Edo period (1603-1868). Manabe (2016) traces how dance has been historically constrained in Japan through legal, social, and moral codes, making it difficult for an organic and embodied dance culture to emerge. Following American occupation post WWII, the feared arrival of Western liberalism repurposed dancehalls into cabarets for the American GI (Hartley, 2015, p.4). The fearful government introduced the *Fueiho* Law in 1948, which classified dancehalls and clubs as "adult entertainment venues" and required them to close

between midnight and sunrise (Manabe, 2016, p.293). This law remained in place until 2016, when the government decided to relax the law, allowing venues to apply for a licence to allow dancing past midnight. The Tokyoite underground emerged as a convoluted effort to create a balance between maintaining face with the Japanese government but also reasoning with the new expressive freedom granted by American entertainment culture. A rebellion against both Japanese and American culture, the Tokyoite underground grew as a resistance against the parental class (Thornton, 1996, p.12). Thornton theorises subcultural capital as being built upon rebellion – expression in the face of restriction.

My interview with YESBØWY was carried with me as the night continued. I found my way back to Nyoro, who took me to visit a club in Shimokitazawa, Counter Club. The most fitting word to describe my experience in Counter Club is naked. The room was naked. In such an intimate setting with a low ceiling, an art gallery tucked into one corner and a food bar near the entrance, the music and fashion spoke for itself. The setting, distinct from the high-energy atmosphere of WOMB, offered a quieter perspective on Tokyo's multidimensional club culture. People crowded around the DJ booth that was tagged to the end of the bar, dominating the space as if sound and drink were the two lifelines keeping the club afloat. The club could not have been bigger than the ground floor of a London townhouse, with dark walls and mood lighting that sucked you in and compelled you to stay. Two hip hoppers stood out as soon as I entered, lost in a world of their own. Dressed as if filming a 90s music video, bucket hats paired with oversized graphic tees and wide-legged jorts, bouncing to the laid-back boom-bap beat and occasionally following along with the English lyrics, they filled the club with a contagious energy.

Drawing from YESBØWY's interview, these men epitomised the affective synergy between a DJ and their audience. Graffitied walls only hold power as social artefacts when they are painted on, they become both the medium and the message, borrowing from McLuhan. Fashion thus holds power within the hip hop subculture as the physical paint that decorates our

bodies, serving to cover us up physically, but render us emotionally and affectively naked to those around us. The metaphysical relationship between sound and fashion manifests itself in such charged settings as clubs, where performance is foregrounded both by the DJ and the audience. Such a creatively raw environment flattens social and creative hierarchies, viewing everyone as a participant to the collective embodied experience of bodily freedom.

In this chapter I have explored how the Tokyoite club serves as a dynamic archive of identity, rebellion, and affect. My interview with YESBØWY exposed me to the nuances of embodiment through performance and the affective power of fashion as social and emotional tags that decorate our bodies, which I have carried into the wider Tokyoite clubbing scene. By understanding the nuances of affect, and the history of the Japanese body, we reckon with the power of clothing, sound, and gesture as a means of societal freedom and subcultural rebellion.

EPILOGUE

I started researching for this ethnography a year ago, nurturing my teenage interest in Japanese music cultures. I arrived in Tokyo with the hopes of understanding contemporary Japanese hip hop and the development of the Tokyoite clubbing scene through embodiment and performance. My journey through the streets, feeling out of place in a culture completely unfamiliar to me, gave me a paradoxical sense of blissful isolation. Each club I went to was grounded in a strong affective pull; although people were not dancing there was a heightened sense of awareness and community that I often don't see in a nightclub setting. The music held the personality of the DJ, and the audience responded to the music, injecting their individuality into the space.

Initially, I felt that my presence in Tokyo's clubs would remain purely observational as a researcher gathering data. However, the longer I stayed present within these spaces, I began to understand that my body was part of the club's performance; embodiment is something we are constantly participating in. Wetherell's concept of affect (2012) emphasises how emotions circulate in collective spaces, melding bodies together. My presence as an outsider in the Japanese art scene introduced a different form of symbolic capital, one that tore down the wall of homogeneity that separated me from Japanese culture.

Travelling to and from sites of research was where I felt most distant from Tokyo's art scene. My presence as a foreigner impacted how I was perceived and fed into my initial impression of Japan's traditional-focused society. However, the more time I spent in Tokyo the more I began to develop an understanding of embodiment through accepting my position as an outsider. My assumption shifted from embodiment as a solely physical concept to an acknowledgement of the universality of symbolic presence.

An important issue I had to tackle during my research trip was the illusion of objectivity. Entering Tokyo's clubs as both a researcher and participant complicated my understanding of observation and embodiment. Initially I maintained a neutral perspective, but through the affective pull between everyone present, I was forced to confront this illusion. Participating rather than observing shaped my understanding of how bodies negotiate with belonging and self-expression, especially in HVEN, where individuality shone through with blinding light. Through this ethnography, I learned that to truly understand a cultural space, it is necessary to be a body within the crowd.

The greatest limiting factor to my complete immersion into Tokyo's club culture was the language barrier. At times messages would assume an altered meaning when crossing the border between English and Japanese, but I reconciled this by giving my interviewees the chance to feel as comfortable as they could. I met YESBØWY at his store, Yanny at a cafe he loves, and Dabo while at dinner with his friend – to list a few.

My key research question developed significantly after my trip to Tokyo. Initially, I approached my research on Japanese hip hop and clubbing from an academic and racial standpoint, focusing on the politics of hip hop without giving much thought to the humanity behind hip hop's globalisation. After seeing how bodies were transformed by sound, and how DJs painted spaces with music, my research question evolved from how hip hop infiltrated Tokyo's clubbing scene into an exploration of artistic expression through the body as a social artefact, a graffitied wall in motion. By looking at the careers of artists like Dabo and Coma-Chi, it is evident that identity in hip hop is not fixed, and every aspect of Japanese hip hop, from the music to mannerisms, plays an important role within the ever-evolving network. The symbolic power of fashion, music, and body language makes them important semiotic actors in the network that holds Tokyo's unique nightlife together. Taking Schacter's theorisation of graffiti as ornament, I developed my thesis to

look at how personal and local cultures collide within individuals when mediating their presence as individual components of a larger body of creativity.

An interesting comparison that I have drawn throughout this essay is between Currid-Halkett's exploration of New York's creative currency and Tokyo's approach to clubbing. Currid-Halkett pays close attention to the "rich cultural history of the importance of informal places where creative people hang out" (2009, p.89), labelling social interaction in clubs as contributing to an "institution". The creative economy in New York City relies heavily on strategic moves, constructing an image of a social network plagued by the fast pace of Western consumption. While NYC clubs serve as "laboratories" for cultural collision and experimentation between creatives (2009, p.88), Tokyo's clubs function as curated archives of cultural memory. The clubs I visited and the people I have spoken to helped me draw this conclusion; each aspect of musical subcultures in Japan relies not only on music, but on fashion, mannerisms, and rituals.

The emotional landscape of Tokyo clubs reflects the complexity of Japan's subcultures that dictate the art world. While subcultures serve as havens for different groups of people, clubs bring these people together with the shared aim of personal expression. It is this self-reflection that creates a uniquely connected clubbing culture. Throughout this ethnography I have explored how music, fashion, and dance intermingle to create a concentrated energy source within clubs. Each body is a canvas on which personality is displayed through movement.

Globalisation brought hip hop culture to Japan, and with it brought reimagined priorities surrounding club culture. However, through Condry's concept of Genba Globalisation (2006, p.87) we can understand that Tokyo's clubbing scene evolved into a distinctly local form. Nostalgia acts as a political and creative act, binding bodies to each other and infusing Japanese clubbing culture with a symbolic embodiment not found in New York's clubbing scene.

As I left Tokyo, the echoes of the clubs rang in my ears and beat heavily in my heart. Everyone I met carried a colourful history, their creative personae reflecting the dynamic evolution of Japanese hip hop and its impact on the city's nightlife. I entered with a clear canvas and held it out as I walked the streets of Tokyo and engaged with the culture. I walked away with a new layer of skin, a canvas graffitied by my experiences and carefully reimagined.

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APPENDIX A: CUREC APPROVAL EMAIL

Subject: CUREC 1B: "Japanese Club Culture: A Study in Music and Fashion",[R E D A C T E D] - ethics approval
Date: Friday 12 July 2024 at 11:19:59 British Summer Time
From: Charles Brassley on behalf of Social Sciences & Humanities IDREC
To: [REDACTED]
CC: Jacob Bird, Jason Stanyek
Attachments: image002.jpg

Dear Anon ,

I am writing to acknowledge receipt of your CUREC 1B application entitled 'Japanese Club Culture: A Study in Music and Fashion'. The application was reviewed and approved by Jason Stanyek, the Director of Undergraduate Studies in the Faculty of Music. No further approval via the Social Sciences and Humanities Interdivisional Research Ethics Committee (SSH IDREC) is required for applications reviewed under the CUREC 1B process. As such, the project will not receive a formal letter of ethical approval from the SSH IDREC.

The ethics reference for your application is **C1B-24TT-Music-R94919/RE001**. Please add this reference to your CUREC 1B form and include it on any documents for the research participants (such as a participant information sheet).

Please note that this approval is contingent on the research project adhering to the criteria set out in the CUREC 1B guidance. Please ensure, therefore, that you comply with the conditions of this process and, should anything change in the course of the project, you should discuss this with your supervisor to determine whether this requires further review and approval by the SSH IDREC.
All the best for your research – we hope it goes well.

Best wishes,
Charlie

UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD RESEARCH SERVICES

researchsupport.admin.ox.ac.uk

Charlie Brassley
Research Ethics Administrator

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Working days: Wednesday, Thursday, Friday

Please refer to our privacy notice for details of how we capture, process and hold personal information in line with current UK data protection legislation.
I follow the Email Charter to help reverse the problems caused by email overload.

APPENDIX B: FORMAL AND SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEWS

Name	***Role***	***Date***	***Location***	***Format***
Dabo	Rapper	18.08.24	Dinner at Nick's house	In-person (interpreted)
YESBØWY	DJ/Designer	24.08.24	Muze Gallery and Bar	In-person
Yanny	DJ	22.08.24	Café ROSTO	In-person
Coma-Chi	Rapper	23.08.24	Allpress Espresso Toranomon	In-person
Robin Rastenberger	Club Owner	01.09.24	HVEN	Semi-structured in-person interview
Shing02	Rapper	12.08.24	N.A	Email
MC Pero	Rapper	19.08.24	The Roasted Coffee Laboratory	In-person